they weren't properly rewarded for helping an elderly customer or for being extra patient with a rude customer? In some cases, they might now try complaining to Tripadvisor, which collapses the boundary between the money market and the reputation market, turning the fuzzy reputation of restaurants and hotels into a mathematical system of precise points. The idea of social credit is to expand this surveillance method from restaurants and hotels to everything. In the most extreme type of social credit systems, every person gets an overall reputation score that takes into account whatever they do and determines everything they can do.

For example, you might earn 10 points for picking up litter from the street, get another 20 points for helping an old lady cross the road, and lose 15 points for playing the drums and disturbing the neighbours. If you get a high enough score, it might give you priority when buying train tickets or a leg up when applying to university. If you get a low score, potential employers may refuse to give you a job, and potential dates may refuse your advances. Insurance companies may demand higher premiums and judges may inflict harsher sentences.

Some people might see social credit systems as a way to reward pro-social behaviour, punish egotistical acts and create kinder and more harmonious societies. The Chinese government, for example, explains that its social credit systems could help fight corruption, scams, tax evasion, false advertising and counterfeiting, and thereby establish more trust between individuals, between consumers and corporations, and between citizens and government institutions.[50] Others may find systems that allocate precise values to every social action demeaning and inhuman. Even worse, a comprehensive social credit system will annihilate privacy and effectively turn life into a never-ending job interview. Anything you do, anytime, anywhere, might affect your chances of getting a job, a bank loan, a husband or a prison sentence. You got drunk at a college party and did something legal but shameful? You participated in a political demonstration? You're friends with someone who has a low credit score? This will be part of your job interview – or criminal sentencing – both in the short term and even decades later. The social credit system might thereby become a totalitarian control system.

Of course, the reputation market always controlled people and made them conform to the prevailing social norms. In most societies people have always feared losing face even more than they have feared losing money.